

DEDC02 · ADVANCED RESEARCH METHOD

Research Ethics and Integrity

Consent · risk · confidentiality · data management · research integrity

Research Ethics and Integrity

Follow one social science study from ethical design and IRB review through consent, risk, data and the integrity of its published record.

Opening activity · shared word cloud

What comes to mind when you hear “research ethics and integrity”?

Add up to three general words or brief phrases from your own device, without names or personal details.

STUDENTS

Add your words ↗

INSTRUCTOR

View the word cloud ↗

You should be able to...

- 01 **Apply ethical principles** to questions of autonomy, harm, dignity and independence in social science research.
- 02 **Review an IRB package** for consistency across recruitment, procedures, consent, risk and safeguards.
- 03 **Explain meaningful consent** and plan confidentiality and data management from collection through disposal.
- 04 **Assign authorship and CRediT roles responsibly** while managing conflicts of interest and dual roles.
- 05 **Recognise threats to the research record**, including fabrication, falsification, plagiarism and selective reporting.
- 06 **Apply journal AI policies** to disclosure, participant data protection and verification of AI-assisted work.

Opening dilemma · vote and discuss

A teacher invites their own students into a doctoral study.

Fictional case: the study uses classroom writing, interviews and AI-platform logs from 16-year-old students. The invitation is about to go into the class chat.

Which first redesign best addresses the immediate pressure to participate?

A · Ask students to sign during class

B · Use an independent invitation route

C · Keep only the platform logs

Choose privately, then defend your choice with a partner.

► **Compare the reasoning after discussion**

Six principles for ethical social research

Source: The UK Economic and Social Research Council's [Framework for Research Ethics](#) ↗ guides researchers, organisations and ethics committees. It treats ethics as a responsibility from study design through publication and data reuse.

01

Benefit and harm

Seek benefits for people and society while reducing foreseeable risks and harms.

02

Rights and dignity

Respect the rights and dignity of individuals and groups affected by the study.

03

Informed, voluntary participation

Where possible, people should choose freely on the basis of suitable information.

04

Integrity and transparency

Carry out the study honestly and make its conduct and reporting transparent.

05

Responsibility and accountability

Make clear who is responsible for decisions, safeguards and responses.

06

Independence and conflicts

Protect research independence and disclose unavoidable conflicts.

Ethics continues after approval

ESRC framework: Ethical reflection covers planning, fieldwork, dissemination, archiving, sharing and future use of data. Responsibility continues throughout these stages after approval.

BEFORE COLLECTION

Design and review

Specify recruitment, consent, instruments, foreseeable risks and data routes; obtain required permissions and ethics approval.

DURING COLLECTION

Notice and respond

Revisit consent; watch for distress, pressure, unintended disclosure and changes to the approved procedure.

AFTER COLLECTION

Protect and report

Limit access, check quotations for identifiability, honour the data plan, report findings faithfully and credit contributors.

A course application draft is a reasoning exercise. Recruitment and human-participant data collection require formal ethics approval first.

Read the case like an ethics reviewer.

FICTIONAL PROPOSAL

AI writing feedback in secondary school

The teacher-researcher recruits their own class.

Student drafts, interviews and platform logs are combined.

Interview quotations may appear in a journal article.

The draft says: “Participation is voluntary and all data are anonymous.”

Reviewer’s questions

Who invites students, and who learns who declined?

What information leaves the AI platform?

Could a quotation identify a student or the school?

Which answer would most change the design? Discuss with a partner.

What goes into the ethics application?

Local source: The [CityU School of Education notice](#) ↗ asks students for supervisor approval, an application form or statement, the proposal and research tools, including consent materials where relevant. Data collection starts only after approval.

CORE Application and protocol Purpose, people, procedure, benefits, risks, safeguards and responsibilities.	PARTICIPANT-FACING Recruitment and consent Invitation, information sheet, consent choices, assent or guardian materials where relevant.	METHOD-FACING Instruments and permissions Questionnaires, guides, observation plans, access letters and debriefing where relevant.	DATA-FACING Data management Data-flow map, access roles, third-party services, retention and disposal.
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Attach only what the proposed design actually needs. Every attachment should agree with the application.

Connect the form to the study documents

The [School's current notice and application form](#) [↗] set the local submission requirements. These six areas show how a reviewer can check whether the proposal, recruitment text, consent and data plan tell the same story.

▶ Purpose and design	▶ People and recruitment	▶ Procedures and instruments
▶ Consent and choice	▶ Risk and response	▶ Data and outputs

The submitted files must agree

The [School’s application notice ↗](#) requires the form or statement alongside the proposal and research tools. Each pair below contains two equally important parts of that submission.

▶ Application form “No identifiable data.”	Interview and recruitment plans Audio interviews and a named list.	▶ Application form “No foreseeable risk.”	Recruitment invitation The teacher invites their own students in class.
▶ Consent sheet “Withdraw at any time.”	Analysis and publication plan Quotations are published after transcription.	▶ Data management plan “Only researchers have access.”	Method protocol Third-party AI transcription is used.

Pairs: name the contradiction, suggest a repair aloud, then open the explanation.

Consent is an ongoing choice

[ESRC consent guidance](#) ↗ calls for clear information, freedom from pressure and a choice people can revisit. [BERA \(British Educational Research Association\)](#) ↗ is a UK learned society for education research; its [2024 ethical guidelines](#) ↗ apply these duties to research with learners.

01 Invitation Why me? Who asks? Can I take time?	02 Information What happens, for how long, and with which data?	03 Choice Can I refuse parts such as recording or future sharing?	04 Continuity Can I pause, skip, withdraw or ask later?
Active consent · opt in A person affirmatively agrees after receiving information; record the choice. For minors, required guardian permission and the young person’s own agreement are separate decisions.		Passive consent · opt out A missing response is treated as permission after a notice. Silence may mean the notice was missed. This route needs explicit justification and prior approval under applicable rules.	

For the school study, obtain the required permission for interviews, drafts and AI logs through an affirmative choice. [US OHRP’s parental-permission FAQ](#) ↗ gives one jurisdiction-specific example; check the local review requirements.

Which promises exceed this study's safeguards?

“By signing, you agree to all activities and future uses. All data are anonymous. There are no risks. You can withdraw at any time.”

Discuss how to describe recording, confidentiality and withdrawal more accurately. Then compare a possible revision.

► Compare a possible revision

Risk includes social and reputational harm

The [ESRC risk and benefit guidance](#) ↗ considers participants, wider groups and researchers. It asks for the likely scale of harm, expected benefit, safeguards and a response if harm occurs.



Trace each risk from the activity through possible harm, prevention and response to the remaining risk.

Rehearse the response while the stakes are low.

01 · Distress

An interviewee becomes upset and asks whether the recording can be erased.

► Discuss, then open

02 · Disclosure

A participant reports a serious safety concern after you promised “complete confidentiality.”

► Discuss, then open

03 · Scope change

A school offers additional attendance records after the study begins.

► Discuss, then open

Choose one scenario to discuss, then reveal the suggested response.

Privacy, confidentiality, anonymity

The [ESRC consent guidance](#) ↗ asks researchers to explain limits to confidentiality; its [risk guidance](#) ↗ asks who may be identifiable. The [ICO anonymisation guidance](#) ↗ explains that data remain identifiable if the team can reconnect them to a person.

PRIVACY

Control over access

Who is approached, observed or recorded, and in which setting?

CONFIDENTIALITY

Control over disclosure

Researchers restrict access to known identities and control what is published.

ANONYMITY

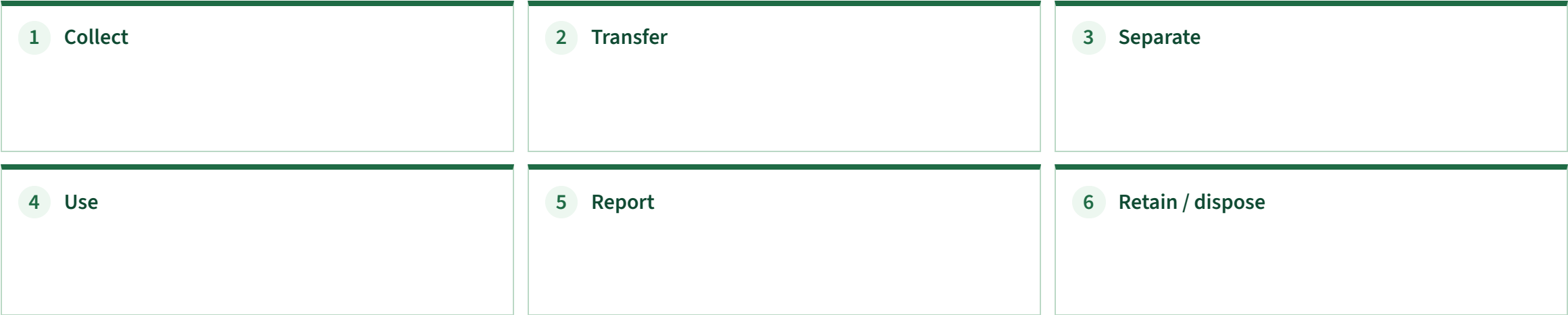
Identity remains untraceable

After names are removed, a voice recording or a quotation about a distinctive classroom experience may still reveal the participant's identity.

Answer: “anonymous”. The team can identify the speaker by matching the recording to a name. The consent form should state who can access the identifiable recording and how it will be protected.

Data management begins before collection

For ESRC-funded work, [ESRC data requirements](#) make curation, management and potential sharing part of the project itself. The interview-file route below makes those responsibilities concrete.



Trace the route together. Notice when another person, device, service or file copy gains access.

Roles and relationships change the decision

BERA's case studies illustrate its 2024 ethical guidelines in practice. In the [insider teacher-researcher case ↗](#), Sarah, a primary teacher, observes a colleague's class. Her responsibilities as researcher and colleague may conflict; similar questions arise when teachers study their own students.

01

Children and young people

Whose permission and whose assent matter? How will refusal be recognised during an activity?

02

Dual roles

When a researcher also teaches, grades or manages participants, can they freely refuse? Who recruits and sees the decision?

03

Conflicts of interest

Could a funder, platform vendor, promotion goal or personal relationship affect design, analysis or reporting? What must be disclosed and managed?

Context shapes participant protection and the independence of the research record. Disclose competing interests; redesign roles or procedures when pressure persists.

Before an application is ready

Six checks before submission.

The application and attachments describe the same people, tasks and data.	A person can decline or withdraw without a teacher or gatekeeper penalising them.
Each important risk has a prevention step, a response and a named owner.	The consent text states what is recorded, who sees it and the limits to withdrawal.
The data plan names tools, locations, access, retention and disposal.	Claims about anonymity, benefit and approval match what can actually be promised.
These checks protect participants at the application stage. The same duty continues when the team analyses, credits and publishes the study.	

Authorship means credit and responsibility

[ALLEA \(All European Academies\)](#) [↗] is the European federation of science and humanities academies. Its [2023 European Code of Conduct for Research Integrity](#) [↗] sets standards across disciplines. On authorship, it asks authors to agree on order, contribute significantly, approve the final work and accept responsibility.

01 · Authorship

Qualify for the byline

Use the journal's authorship criteria to assess each contribution. Providing access, funding or general supervision still requires a separate authorship decision.

02 · Contribution

Describe the work

Record who designed, collected, analysed, drafted, revised and approved the work. Credit non-author help appropriately.

03 · Order

Agree and revisit

Discuss author order early, revisit it when work changes, and obtain all authors' agreement before submission.

A contribution statement makes work visible; the byline and its order remain decisions the authors must justify together.

CRediT describes the work behind a paper

[NISO's CRediT taxonomy ↗](#) names 14 contribution roles. It describes who did what; the target journal's rules still determine who qualifies as an author.

Conceptualization	Methodology
Investigation	Data curation
Formal analysis	Validation
Software	Visualization
Resources	Funding acquisition
Project administration	Supervision
Writing – original draft	Writing – review & editing

Example: Mei — Conceptualization, Methodology, Writing – original draft; Ravi — Investigation, Data curation, Writing – review & editing. Determine authorship and author order separately under the journal's criteria.

Four ways the research record is distorted

The [ALLEA code](#) [↗] identifies fabrication, falsification and plagiarism as research misconduct. It also treats unjustified withholding of results and selective citation as unacceptable practices.

Fabrication
Inventing an interview or response that never occurred.

Falsification
Changing a transcript, code or dataset to support a preferred result.

Plagiarism
Using another scholar’s words, ideas or materials without proper credit.

Selective reporting
Hiding contradictory cases or outcomes so findings appear stronger.

Keep a traceable record of design changes, exclusions and analytic choices; report limits and disconfirming evidence.

AI disclosure depends on the journal

Two publishing sources: *Language Testing* has its own [October 2024 guidance ↗](#); Elsevier publishes a broader [journal policy ↗](#) relevant to *System*. Both keep authors responsible for AI-assisted work.

Language Testing · journal-specific guidance

Identify the tool, task and purpose. Acknowledge generative AI used for language editing; describe research use in Methods. AI analysis of participants' qualitative data normally requires consent through ethics review, plus accuracy and privacy checks.

[Read the journal guidelines ↗](#)

System · Elsevier publisher policy

Declare substantive AI assistance in manuscript preparation in a separate statement; basic spelling and grammar checks are exempt. Explain research-process use in Methods. Verify output and references, protect data, and keep authors accountable.

[Read the current publisher policy ↗](#)

Policies differ and can change. Before submitting, check the target journal's current wording and protect participant data when using external tools.

System · published disclosure and correction

Published records show disclosure and its limits

A *System* article shows a writing-related AI declaration alongside participant protections. A separate *System* corrigendum shows why AI-suggested references still need independent verification.

System (2025) · writing disclosure

Lázaro-Ibarrola et al., young multilingual readers

The article declares Talk to Claude for readability and proofreading, followed by author review. Its ethics statement also documents institutional approval, parental consent and children's choice to participate.

[Inspect the article ↗](#)

System (2026) · published correction

Lin & Tsou, EMI professional development

A corrigendum explains that GPT-4o helped identify references. Several AI-suggested citations were insufficiently verified and needed correction. The authors remained responsible for checking primary sources.

[Inspect the corrigendum ↗](#)

Identify the tool, purpose, study stage, human checks and data permissions. A declaration makes use visible; verify the output independently.

Keep the lesson

Thank you

Keep the research ethics guidance, examples and source links for your next study.